

Community of Practice T&L

Meeting 4

28 May 2026

The meeting focused on the theme of Student Experience. What is the experience of the students in our faculty? Do our students 'enjoy' being on campus? What role does our teaching and learning impact the student experience? The session focused on the three questions below:

1. What are we doing really well?
2. What areas need improvement?
3. What are we ready to let go of?

Below is a summary of the topics of inquiry that have been addressed already (highlighted in green), and the ones that will be addressed in the coming weeks.

Meeting #	Topic if Inquiry
1	Intros
2	What are we good at, what do we improve on, what do we let go of
3	technology
4	Student Experience
5	Indigenous Knowledge
6	(c)reativity
7	International
8	Interdisciplinarity
9	Competition
10	TBC

Below is the summary of the meeting.

What are we doing really well?

WIL and Practice-Inspired Teaching

- WIL and practice-inspired teaching are working really well. We are putting in a consistent and largely successful effort in delivering this.
 - It is becoming more challenging to maintain due to the rapid rate of change in industry. Adapting to this and navigating it is something we need to ensure our students are prepared for.
 - It is also important how we communicate this experience to students; we often present it as exciting and engaging, but the reality on the ground can be more demanding and complex.
- Through WIL, we have strong relationships with industry:
 - We bring industry into our classes
 - Provide students with access to industry leaders through lectures
 - Collaborate with industry to build curriculum
- Internship pathways are a key strength:

- Some schools offer internships (both paid and unpaid)
- Some partnerships have developed into strong collaborations, where industry partners contribute to writing the subject (e.g. cadetships)
- In some cases, subjects that collaborate with industry also lead directly to internship opportunities
- We are also becoming effective at influencing industry practices:
 - We are able to guide partners and influence their practices toward improving how they structure and support student internships and create more ethical frameworks for student engagement.
 - There is an opportunity here to develop clearer benchmarking or guidance for academics on what to pursue or avoid in these partnerships

Student Agency and Learning Experience:

- In various subjects, students have the ability to choose the theme or direction of their work:
 - This significantly improves the student experience
 - It gives students agency and ownership over their learning
- We work towards developing students who are adaptable to a changing world, and we are trying to make this an engaging and positive experience for them

Student Societies and Engagement

- Student societies are working very well:
 - They are more successful than staff in attracting students into extracurricular activities
- The Faculty is working toward:
 - Strengthening the strategic direction of societies
 - Encouraging them to think more holistically beyond individual schools or disciplines

Student Support and Responsiveness

- We are very strong at supporting students, particularly when they face challenges:
 - Students who are not progressing at the same rate are well supported
 - Teaching teams are flexible in responding to student needs
- We actively adapt our delivery:
 - Updating tasks when needed
 - Reviewing our usual ways of working to relieve pressure
 - Creating space for more adaptable modes of engagement
- Overall, we design a curriculum that is (potential “Catchphrase” here):
 - Adaptable
 - Agile
 - Responsive to student needs

What Areas Need Improvement?

Tension Between Employment and Student Experience

- Although some schools have been very successful in securing employment pathways through internships, this has resulted in students securing a job while they are still studying and thus pulling their attention away from campus.
- This impacts the student experience in the final year, particularly in terms of engagement and presence

Preparing Students for Industry Earlier

- We need to better prepare students to navigate practices in creative industries and improve their understanding of how the profession operates
- Currently, this is often introduced too late in the degree. There is value in embedding this earlier
- There is a need to reflect on whether we are exposing students to the realities of the profession early enough. This links back to:
 - Expectations
 - Preparedness
 - Student understanding of what they are working toward

First-Year Experience and Orientation

- The first semester experience is critical, and currently quite challenging:
 - Many students enter Building 6 and feel lost
 - There is a significant adjustment period in understanding workload, expectations, and the value of the degree
- Students tend to go through a “rite of passage” before fully settling in
 - Improving this early experience could significantly impact overall student experience
- Potential improvements:
 - Stronger and more targeted orientation activities
 - Better guidance on navigating the building and facilities
 - A temporary physical touchpoint (e.g. a 2-week booth at the start of semester) for support and guidance

Belonging and Campus Engagement

- We need to do more to create a sense of belonging. Students should want to come to campus, not just attend because they have to.
- This is not only about attendance, but about:
 - Identity
 - Community
 - Feeling part of something

Language and Academic Preparedness

- There are concerns about students who appear not to meet minimum language expectations. Some struggle with basic English
 - This impacts their own learning but also the experience of other students who are in the same group with some of these students.
 - Tutors end up spending significantly more time with these students and less time with others, impacting the overall learning experience in the classroom.
- University or faculty initiatives to help address and support these students will help mitigate this issue.

What Are We Ready to Let Go of?

- A grade-driven student experience:
 - Moving away from over-emphasising grades as the primary form of motivation
 - Recognising that this limits the diversity of experiences students engage with
- Instead, we want to move toward:
 - Broader definitions of success
 - Alternative forms of recognition
- Suggestion:
 - Introducing student awards or recognition that recognises student achievements beyond grades (eg. Best presenter, best peer mentor, etc.). These can be either school or faculty driven.